



A SHIP-BREAKING UNIT
ON THE ALANG COAST

Photographs by SHAILESH RAVAL/www.indiatodaymag.com

Downturn Boom

- In 2009-10, as many as 348 ships were dismantled at Alang, almost matching the highest tally of 361 in 1999.
- The ship-breaking unit here has also helped the growth of the second-hand goods industry that subsists on recycled stuff generated by broken ships, including furniture, kitchen appliances, boilers and a diverse range of machines.
- The international recession has brought not just the Alang ship-breaking yard to life but also the nearby princely town of Bhavnagar where many new steel processing units and oxygen plants have come up.
- People from far off places, particularly Bihar, Jharkhand, West Bengal and Orissa, have once again flocked to Alang in search of better jobs.



- The ship-breaking yard is an ecological boon as it makes steel from scrap whereas others exploit iron ore to make steel. Plus, ship-breaking doesn't need water while the iron ore-based steel industry needs a whopping 15,000-20,000 litres of water to make one tonne of steel.

in short supply. Today, the total volume of steel produced here is 5,000 metric tonnes (MT) per day. In 2007-08, it was only about 1,600 tonnes," says Nitin Kanakia, director of Vinubhai Steel Company.

With their earnings stabilised, the workers are on a high, literally. The skilled ones can earn between Rs 5,000 to Rs 15,000 a month. Says Madhavprasad Peksha, 47, a loader at Haryana Ship Breakers Pvt. Ltd, "I have no words to describe how I feel about Alang's revival. Even my fortunes have revived." After his company shut shop in 2004, Peksha went back to his native place, Jharkhand, to join his family but there too he hit a financial dead-end. So, he decided to come back to Alang and earn his liv-